

EMERGENCY PROTOCOL FOR INJURED WILDLIFE

Field Stabilization, Chemical-Free Capture, and First-Response Management

CRITICAL SAFETY MANDATE: Wild animals do not understand human intent. An injured raptor, mammal, or reptile perceives rescue as a predatory attack and will deploy talons, teeth, or musk defensively. Personal human protection is the absolute priority.

1. The Four-Step Field Assessment

- 1. Determine True Distressed Status:** Observe from a distance. Look for asymmetric wing carriage, active heavy bleeding, visual tracking loss, or persistent neurological tremors.
- 2. Rule Out Normal Developmental Stages:** Fledgling birds (feathered birds with short tails hopping on the ground) and hidden white-tailed fawns are typically normal behavioral patterns. Unless visibly injured or exposed to domestic cats/dogs, leave them undisturbed.
- 3. Analyze Environmental Risk Factor:** Ensure capture lines do not force wildlife into active traffic corridors, deep bodies of water, or up high-voltage structures.
- 4. Prepare the Capture Environment:** Have a dark, non-wire containment box ready *before* initiating contact. Cages with exposed open bars strip bird feathers and exacerbate panic-induced trauma.

2. Species-Specific Containment Techniques

- **Songbirds & Small Passerines:** Approach from behind. Gently cast a lightweight cloth or pillowcase over the individual. Secure the wings flush to the torso, and place the animal inside a paper bag or a small cardboard box.
- **Raptors (Hawks, Owls, Falcons): Talons pose the primary physical hazard.** Wear heavy, puncture-resistant welding leathers. Drop a thick towel or blanket over the bird. Pin the wings securely while managing the legs; immediately lift by the thighs into a rigid plastic pet carrier.
- **Small-to-Medium Mammals (Squirrels, Opossums):** Use heavy leathers or a thick heavy towel. Secure the head gently from behind to eliminate lateral biting ranges. Alternatively, place an inverted plastic bin or trash can over the animal, slide a flat piece of sturdy cardboard underneath, and flip the unit.
- **Waterfowl & Long-Legged Wading Birds (Hérons, Egrets):** Herons strike defensively at human eyes with extreme accuracy. **Eye protection (safety glasses) is mandatory.** Control the long neck and sharp beak first, wrap the wings close, and place inside a well-ventilated container.

3. Critical Anti-Shock Field Therapeutics

Thermodynamic Fluid Failure (Shock): Internal thermal degradation kills wildlife faster than localized skeletal trauma. Keep the animal in an environment maintaining baseline target parameters.

- **Absolute Visual and Auditory Deprivation:** The sound of a human voice, car radios, or the presence of barking domestic pets can cause fatal stress cardiomyopathy in wild deer and birds. Keep transport units fully enclosed, warm, and dead silent.
- **Indirect Thermal Management:** Place a chemical hand-warmer or hot water bottle wrapped inside a thick towel inside one corner of the carrier. Ensure the animal has sufficient physical space to voluntarily crawl away from the heat grid if it begins overheating.

- **The Zero-Oral Mandate:** Do not give water, milk, or raw food. Dehydrated or shocked wild animals cannot swallow safely; attempts to inject fluid via a syringe often cause fatal pulmonary aspiration.

4. Field Extraction Documentation

Every field extraction requires logging structural spatial orientation metrics. Record the exact origin site (GPS decimal coordinate parameters or exact trail crossroads). Because migratory wildlife must be returned directly to their native home ranges or specific microclimates post-rehabilitation, losing location accuracy risks permanent displacement.